societies—or, for the very elite, the lawns of private clubs. Essentially a community gathering, the streets were its natural home. Till three years ago, that is.

After the pandemic, when Gujarat stilled its dance steps, the elite began organising private garbas at farmhouses and small party plots in 2022. The fear of big crowds—and infection—was still there. But the experience of curated gigs was appreciated so much, and by an ever-widening garba circle of urban revellers, that commercial garba boomed. From under 100 across Gujarat in 2019, the numbers have breached 300 in each of its four main cities—Ahmedabad, Surat, Vadodara and Rajkot—by 2025. This year also logs a 20 per cent jump in venues over last year.

The cost of passes, too, has shot up, admits Jaydeep Mehta, a veteran garba organiser for over three decades and president of Event Management Federation Global. Sold on booking platforms now, they range from Rs 12,000 on the higher side to an average of Rs 1,500 per person per night. They are sold out pronto, and then sold in black for up to Rs 25,000. Each venue logs average nightly footfalls of 3,000; larger organisers claim nearly 8,000 on all nine nights. The festival itself has gotten longer, extending to nearly 20 nights, beginning a weekend before Navratri and ending a week after Dussehra.

The experience, too, is scaling up—it's now akin to a luxury wedding, starting with an elaborate invite sent a month ahead, to luxurious filmset-like décor, curated food lounges, makeup zones, foot massage, shopping, Gujarati star singers and, a level above that, VIP access for the upper crust.



Takeaways

- **The Navratri industry, with garba events as its centrepiece, has grown 33% over 2024**
- **From just 100 private garbas across Gujarat in 2019, this year counted 300+ in each big city**
- **Tickets, priced anywhere from Rs 1,500 to Rs 12,000, get sold out promptly. They sell in black for as high as Rs 25,000**
- **Stage, set, tent, lighting and decor experts, local designers, artisans, caterers get business equivalent to wedding season**
- **Gujarati star singers such as Aditya Gadhvi, Jigrra, Ishani dump Mumbai for local gigs**

RED & WHITE LOVE

The rage this season is theme garba—sporting names like *safed ishq*, *safed parindey*, *laal ishq* (white love, white bird, red love, et al), naturally calling for coordinated attire and décor, and dotted with multiple photo booths—tailormade for Instafame.

All this means the boom ricocheting down a whole set of micro and small industries: stage and tent vendors, music and sound, transport, lighting and décor experts, designers and artisans get business equivalent to the peak marriage season. Fine dining and star hotels suffer some, but Dilip Thakkar, who owns a chain of Gujarati thali restaurants in Ahmedabad, says business at casual hangout joints "jumps at least 20 per cent".

ALL-STAR NITES

A dozen-odd headline artistes command an undisclosed asking price, believed to run into millions per night. Pre-pandemic, artistes used to prefer performing in Mumbai or at diasporic events—the fees would have naturally instilled a greater spring in their step. This year, the popular artistes are alighting on Gujarati cities and towns. Bollywood promos or the fleeting appearance of a starlet as a stage gimmick has made way for young local singers like Aditya Gadhvi, Jigardan Gadhvi, Ishani Dave, Parth Oza, Kinjal Dave, Geeta Rabari, Hardik Dave, Bhoomi Trivedi, Osman Mir, to name a few.

Some celebrate the commercialisation and, indeed, it even feeds into a distinct stated pride in Gujarati culture, rather than being seen as any sort of move away from roots. "Gujaratis have disposable income and they love to spend it on experiences," says food blogger Esha Shah, who began organising a garba in 2018 with husband Rohan Bhatt.

But the 'uber consumerism' has also, perhaps not paradoxically, made the space on the opposite side of the spectrum more attractive. For, the less splashy side of Gujarat lives too. This is quite another flavour of private garba—sans the trappings of luxury, amplifiers and excessive lights—which finds expression on roads leading out of town. In villages and farmhouses surrounding the cities, modestly ticketed events—with the more authentic sound of *dhol* and *shehnai*—find many willing to travel over an hour for just the authenticity. ■